



A narwhal's tusk always spirals the same way. It can grow about 3 ft (1 m) in length and weigh over 20 lbs (10 kg).

Tusk defense

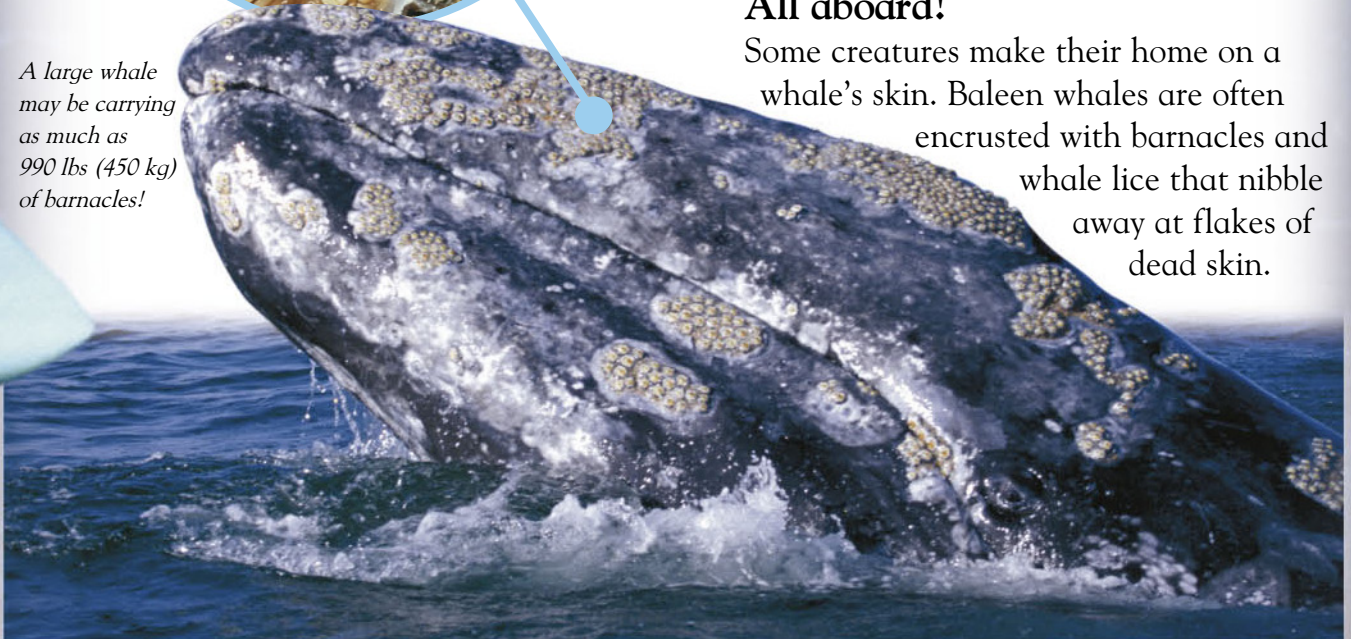
The narwhal's long tusk makes this whale easy to recognize. No one really knows what the tusk is for, especially since only the male narwhals have them. Biologists believe it may be used in fights, so the narwhals know who is boss.



Under a microscope, whale lice look like tiny crabs.

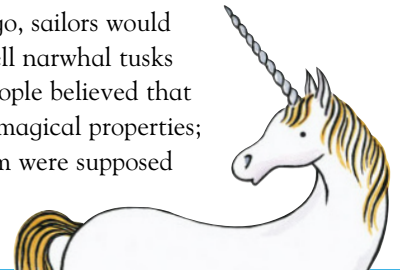


A large whale may be carrying as much as 990 lbs (450 kg) of barnacles!



A LITTLE BIT OF MAGIC

Around 600 years ago, sailors would return to port and sell narwhal tusks as unicorn horns. People believed that a unicorn horn had magical properties; cups made from them were supposed to stop a poison from working.



All aboard!

Some creatures make their home on a whale's skin. Baleen whales are often encrusted with barnacles and whale lice that nibble away at flakes of dead skin.